

Facilitator Guide

For facilitators running the paid build-along. Participants upload an Excel file and watch a generic chatbot turn into a grounded subject-matter expert.

Session at a glance

Tier	Microsoft 365 Copilot — Agent Builder with knowledge
Session length	75 minutes (50 build, 15 explore, 10 Q&A)
Audience	M365 Copilot-licensed users in business teams
Group size	Webinar — no participant cap; chat moderation recommended
Format	Webinar build-along — each participant grounds an agent with a real dataset live on the call
Deliverable	A grounded, query-able assistant for their function's data

What this session unlocks

This is the 'oh, my data' moment. Free agents are clever; grounded agents are useful. Participants stop seeing Copilot as a chat toy and start seeing it as a layer that sits over their real numbers — without leaving Excel.

Prerequisites — confirm before the session

- Every participant has an active M365 Copilot license assigned
- The six sample Excel data files distributed (one per function) before the session
- Each participant has chosen which function they'll build for
- Knowledge upload is enabled at tenant level (check Copilot admin)
- Test one full build in your own tenant the morning of the session
- A backup data file in case someone's download is corrupted

Materials checklist

- The six build-along PDFs (paid Agent Builder versions)
- The six Excel data files in a shared link participants can grab before walking in
- This facilitator guide and a timer
- A printed cheat-sheet of the six agent names for quick choosing

Success criteria

- Every participant has uploaded data and asked at least three grounded questions
- Participants can describe one analytical question only the grounded agent could answer
- At least one participant volunteers a question the agent couldn't answer — that's gold
- Nobody leaves believing the agent is 'just chatting' — they've seen citations

Agenda & Timing

Block-by-block plan. Run the clock visibly — participants build faster when they can see the pace.

Time	Block	Talk track / Action
00:00 - 05:00	Open & frame	Recap free tier. Today: we add their own data. The agent becomes specialist.
05:00 - 10:00	Pick function & download data	Pick function, download the Excel file. Stop here if anyone's stuck — fix now.
10:00 - 25:00	Create agent + upload knowledge	Build agent, upload Excel via Knowledge. Walk the room — uploads can fail silently.
25:00 - 40:00	Add instructions & suggested prompts	Paste from PDF. Highlight the 'use only this data' line in instructions.
40:00 - 55:00	Test live — analytical questions	Use 'Try These Live' page. Push them to ask questions only the data can answer.
55:00 - 65:00	Stretch: break it on purpose	Ask something not in the data. See how the agent handles missing info.
65:00 - 75:00	Q&A and 'where next'	Address security, sharing, what happens at Studio tier.

Pacing tip

The upload step is where sessions slow down. Pre-test the Excel files on a tenant identical to participants' — file size, sheet structure, and column types all affect ingest. Bring a known-good file as a fallback so a flaky download doesn't stall the call.

Facilitator Notes — Step by Step

What to say, what to do, and what to watch for at each build step.

1 Create the agent

Say: Same Create agent flow as the free tier — but now we're going to give it data.

Do: Walk to Agents → Create agent. Name and tone from the PDF.

Watch for: Some tenants split Agent Builder from regular Copilot Chat. Confirm path first.

2 Upload knowledge (the Excel file)

Say: This is the moment a generic chatbot becomes a subject-matter expert.

Do: Knowledge → Add knowledge → File. Upload the Excel. Wait for processing.

Watch for: Big files (>5MB) process slowly. Tell them not to skip ahead — wait for the green check.

3 Paste instructions

Say: The instructions tell the agent how to use the data — and what NOT to invent.

Do: Paste from PDF. Read the 'single source of truth' line out loud.

Watch for: If they skip this, the agent will hallucinate. Don't skip.

Facilitator Notes — Continued

Final build steps, common blockers, and how to keep the room engaged.

4 Add suggested prompts

Say: These become the on-ramp for every new user of the agent.

Do: Three pills from the PDF. Encourage one analytical question of their own.

Watch for: Suggested prompts should match what the data actually supports — coach this.

5 Test with grounded queries

Say: Notice the citations — every claim points back to a row in your file.

Do: Run two prompts from the 'Try These Live' page. Click a citation. Show the source row.

Watch for: First-timers don't notice citations. Point at them explicitly. That's the proof.

Engagement prompts (use when energy drops)

- Who got a citation? Click it — show the room what the agent grounded its answer in.
- Try a question NOT answerable from the data. What did the agent say? (Should refuse.)
- Who has a question they'd never ask the data manually? Try it now — that's the value.
- If you replaced this sample file with last week's real export — what's the first thing you'd ask?

Common Blockers & Q&A Bank

The questions you will be asked. Have these crisp.

Common blockers (and your fix)

- **Upload fails or hangs**

→ File too large or wrong format. Save as .xlsx not .xls. Trim to relevant sheet only.

- **Agent says 'I don't see data about that' for things that are in the file**

→ Column headers in the Excel may be unclear. Rename to plain English; re-upload.

- **Agent hallucinates a number not in the data**

→ Strengthen the instructions — add 'NEVER invent values. If the data doesn't say, say so.'

- **Knowledge tab is missing**

→ Tenant hasn't enabled file knowledge for Agent Builder. Note it; offer to follow up with admin.

- **Citations don't appear**

→ Some answer types don't cite (summaries vs. lookups). Push for a lookup question to see them.

Top participant questions

Q: Who can see the file I uploaded?

A: Only you and anyone you share the agent with. The file sits in the agent's knowledge store, governed by your tenant's Copilot policies.

Q: If I update the Excel, does the agent update too?

A: Not automatically on this tier — you re-upload the new file. On Studio you can connect live sources.

Q: Can it read my SharePoint instead of an Excel?

A: Yes — Agent Builder supports SharePoint sites and selected files as knowledge sources. The build-along uses Excel because it's tangible; SharePoint is the next step.

Q: How big can the file be?

A: Limits vary by tenant; assume a single workbook under ~20MB works well. Split bigger files by sheet.

Q: Why does the answer sometimes drift outside the data?

A: Instructions weren't strict enough. Add explicit refusal language — 'If not in the data, say so' — and retry.

Top participant questions — continued

Q: Is this safe enough for finance / HR data?

A: It stays inside your tenant boundary. For sensitive data, layer DLP and access controls — and consider Studio for proper RLS.

Tier Comparison & Per-Function Reference

Use this to answer 'why this tier, not another?' and to tailor language by function.

When to use which Copilot tier

Tier	Best for	Time to value	Governance
Free Copilot Chat	Pure-instruction agents anyone can build, no data upload	5 minutes	Tenant policies apply; no extra data residency to consider
Paid M365 Copilot	Add your own knowledge (Excel, docs) for grounded answers	15 minutes	Stays inside the tenant; admin governs sharing
Copilot Studio	Full agents with topics, tools, orchestration, evaluations, channels	Hours to days	Solution-managed; DLP, RLS, Entra auth, audit trail
Copilot Cowork	Task-driven recurring work using your live M365 surfaces	10 minutes	Acts as the signed-in user; consent and review-before-send patterns

Per-function quick reference

HR — People Ops Assistant

FOCUS

Headcount, leave, ratings, training % — answered from the workbook.

WATCH FOR

Treat PII as restricted; talk about access controls.

IT — Service Desk Assistant

FOCUS

SLA Met %, P1/P2 queue, hotspots — calculated from the rows.

WATCH FOR

Highlight SLA breaches in answers; don't bury them.

Sales — Pipeline Assistant

FOCUS

Stage, weighted value, slipping deals, stalled activity.

WATCH FOR

Sellers should only see their book — flag the access conversation.

Finance — Budget Assistant

FOCUS

Budget vs actual, variance %, year-end forecast.

WATCH FOR

Cost centre owners must not see others' numbers — flag for prod.

CS — Insights Assistant

FOCUS

Open escalations, SLA Met rate, CSAT, first response time.

WATCH FOR

CSAT comments may contain customer names — handle with care.

Marketing — Campaigns Assistant

FOCUS

ROI, MQL→SQL, channel pipeline ratio, top performers.

WATCH FOR

Be explicit about Live vs Complete vs Planned campaigns.

Closing

Free tier was clever. Paid tier is useful. Studio is industrial. Cowork is automatic.

Closing talk track

Recap the journey: free chat → grounded with data. The agent went from generic to specialist in 15 minutes.

Homework: replace the sample file with one of their real exports and ask three questions they couldn't ask before.

Tease Studio: 'next session, we make the agent take ACTIONS, not just answer.'